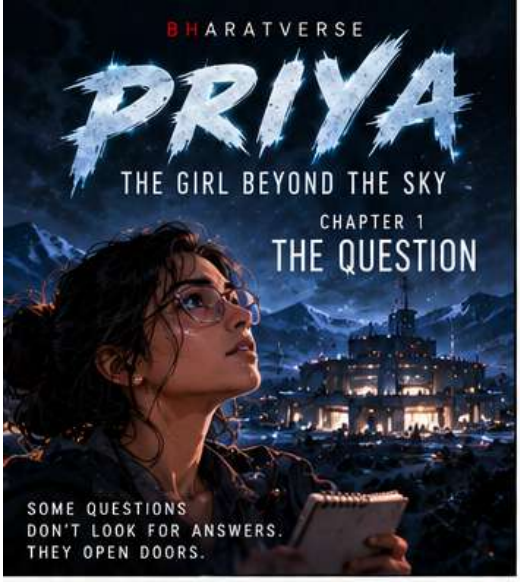
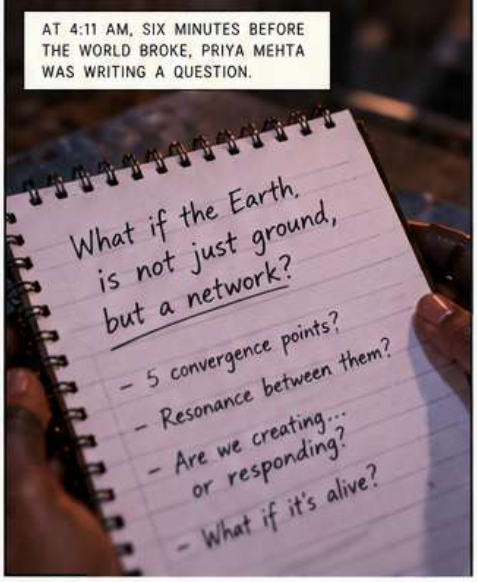
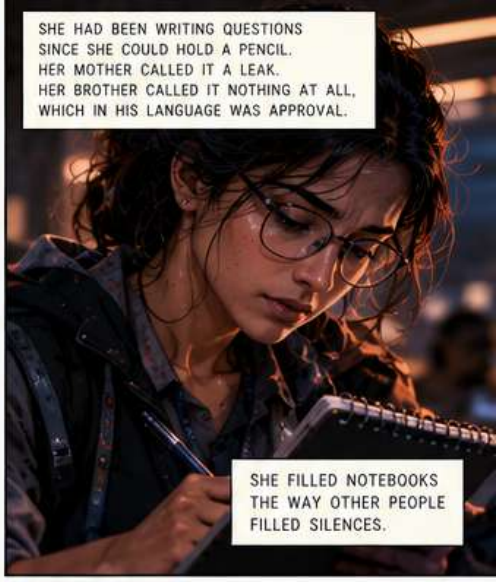
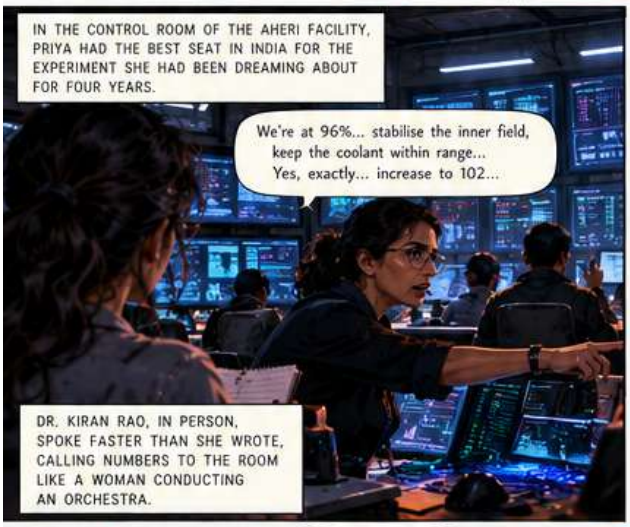
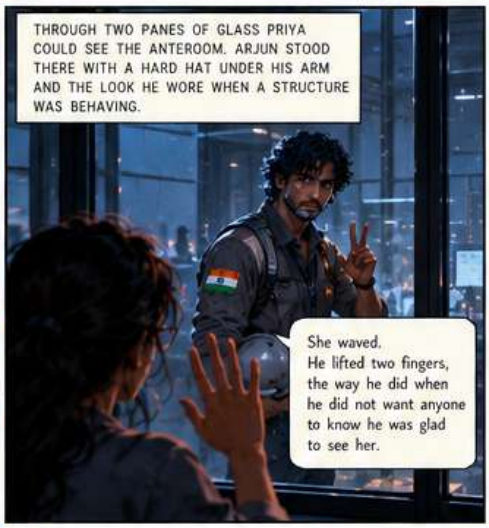
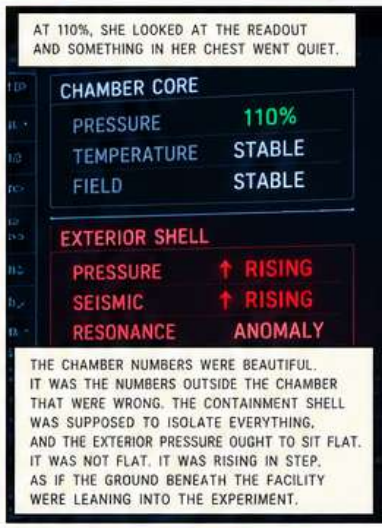

BHARATVERSE
PRIYA
THE GIRL BEYOND THE SKY
CHAPTER 1
THE QUESTION
SOME QUESTIONS
DON'T LOOK FOR ANSWERS.
THEY OPEN DOORS.


AT 4:11 AM, SIX MINUTES BEFORE THE WORLD BROKE, PRIYA MEHTA WAS WRITING A QUESTION.
What if the Earth, is not just ground, but a network?
- 5 convergence points?
- Resonance between them?
- Are we creating... or responding?
- What if it's alive?


SHE HAD BEEN WRITING QUESTIONS SINCE SHE COULD HOLD A PENCIL. HER MOTHER CALLED IT A LEAK. HER BROTHER CALLED IT NOTHING AT ALL, WHICH IN HIS LANGUAGE WAS APPROVAL.
SHE FILLED NOTEBOOKS THE WAY OTHER PEOPLE FILLED SILENCES.


IN THE CONTROL ROOM OF THE AHERI FACILITY, PRIYA HAD THE BEST SEAT IN INDIA FOR THE EXPERIMENT SHE HAD BEEN DREAMING ABOUT FOR FOUR YEARS.
We're at 96%... stabilise the inner field, keep the coolant within range... Yes, exactly... increase to 102...
DR. KIRAN RAO, IN PERSON, SPOKE FASTER THAN SHE WROTE, CALLING NUMBERS TO THE ROOM LIKE A WOMAN CONDUCTING AN ORCHESTRA.


THROUGH TWO PANES OF GLASS PRIYA COULD SEE THE ANTEROOM. ARJUN STOOD THERE WITH A HARD HAT UNDER HIS ARM AND THE LOOK HE WORE WHEN A STRUCTURE WAS BEHAVING.
She waved. He lifted two fingers, the way he did when he did not want anyone to know he was glad to see her.


AT 110%, SHE LOOKED AT THE READOUT AND SOMETHING IN HER CHEST WENT QUIET.
CHAMBER CORE
PRESSURE 110%
TEMPERATURE STABLE
FIELD STABLE
EXTERIOR SHELL
PRESSURE ↑ RISING
SEISMIC ↑ RISING
RESONANCE ANOMALY
THE CHAMBER NUMBERS WERE BEAUTIFUL. IT WAS THE NUMBERS OUTSIDE THE CHAMBER THAT WERE WRONG. THE CONTAINMENT SHELL WAS SUPPOSED TO ISOLATE EVERYTHING, AND THE EXTERIOR PRESSURE OUGHT TO SIT FLAT. IT WAS NOT FLAT. IT WAS RISING IN STEP, AS IF THE GROUND BENEATH THE FACILITY WERE LEANING INTO THE EXPERIMENT.


Dr. Rao... I think the external pressure isn't just a response... what if we aren't making anything, and something is answering?
Not now.
RAO'S MODEL ASSUMES THE PRESSURE IS OURS. WHAT IF IT ISN'T? WHAT IF WE AREN'T MAKING ANYTHING, AND SOMETHING IS ANSWERING?


AT 4:17, RAO SAID "ONE-FORTY."
EXPERIMENT SEQUENCE
01:40
One-forty. All teams, hold position. This is it.
PRIYA HAD TIME TO SAY, "DR. RAO—"

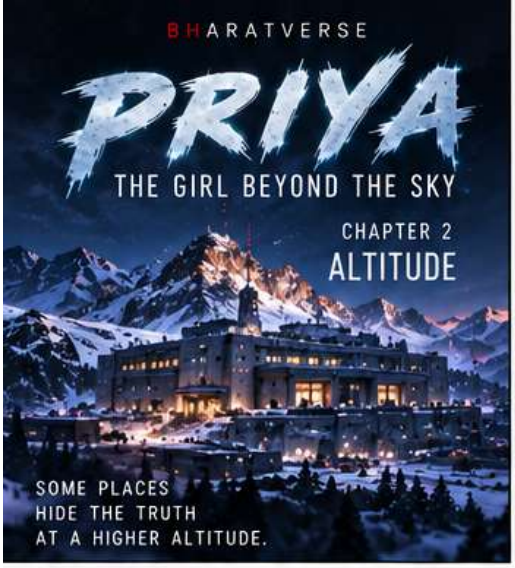

WHAT FOLLOWED, HER BROTHER WOULD LATER DESCRIBE AS A WALL.
FOR PRIYA IT WAS A DOOR. THE PRESSURE WAVE DID NOT STRIKE HER. IT OPENED HER.

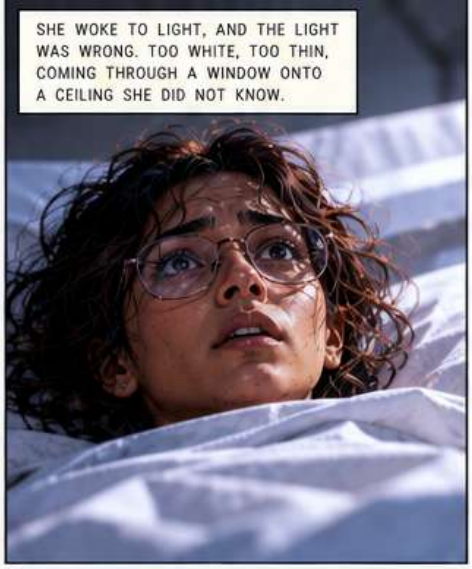

SOMETHING CAME UP THROUGH THE FLOOR, AND SHE SAW IT NOT AS LIGHT AND NOT AS HEAT BUT AS STRUCTURE: A LATTICE OF FAINT SILVER THREADS RUNNING OUT FROM BENEATH THE CHAMBER IN FIVE DIRECTIONS, HUMMING.
SHE WAS STANDING AT THE EXACT PLACE WHERE THEY CROSSED.
SHE THOUGHT, QUITE CLEARLY: OH. IT'S A NETWORK.


THEN THERE WERE HANDS. GLOVED, GENTLE, ONE OVER HER MOUTH. A SMELL OF ANTISEPTIC.
He'll be fine. Breathe.
A SERVICE DUCT DOOR THAT SHOULD HAVE BEEN LOCKED, SWINGING OPEN ON A DARK SHE HID NOT KNOW.

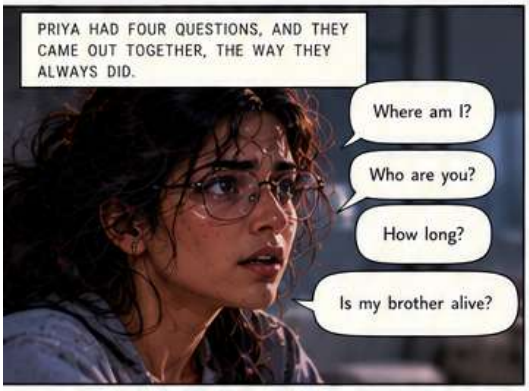

SHE TRIED TO SAY, "MY BROTHER IS IN THE NEXT ROOM," AND A VOICE NEAR HER EAR SAID, LOW AND ALMOST KIND:
He'll be fine. Breathe.

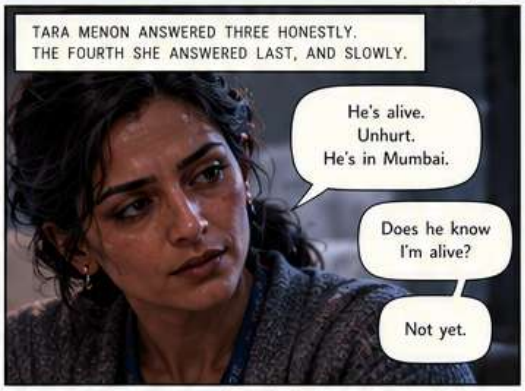

IT TOOK NINETY SECONDS. THEY TOOK THE NOTEPAD TOO.

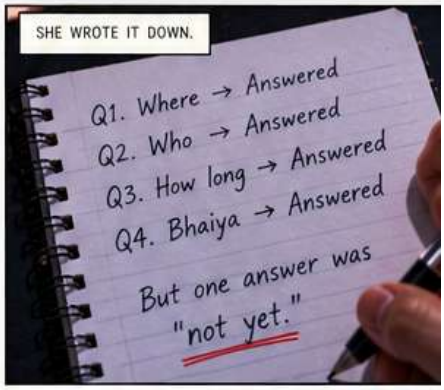

BHARATVERSE
PRIYA
THE GIRL BEYOND THE SKY
CHAPTER 2
ALTITUDE
SOME PLACES
HIDE THE TRUTH
AT A HIGHER ALTITUDE.

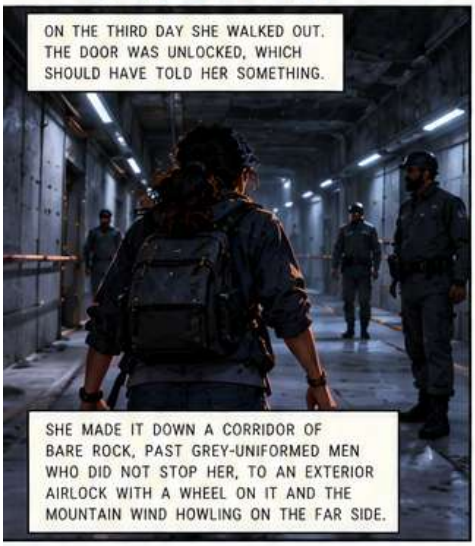

SHE WOKE TO LIGHT, AND THE LIGHT WAS WRONG. TOO WHITE, TOO THIN, COMING THROUGH A WINDOW ONTO A CEILING SHE DID NOT KNOW.


SHE WAS IN A CLEAN WHITE ROOM WITH A WINDOW FULL OF PEAKS. A WOMAN IN A GREY CARDIGAN SAT BESIDE THE BED WITH A MUG OF TEA, FORTY OR SO, TIRED AROUND THE EYES.
Altitude. About thirty-eight hundred metres. It passes.
I'm Tara. You're safe.


PRIYA HAD FOUR QUESTIONS, AND THEY CAME OUT TOGETHER, THE WAY THEY ALWAYS DID.
Where am I?
Who are you?
How long?
Is my brother alive?


TARA MENON ANSWERED THREE HONESTLY. THE FOURTH SHE ANSWERED LAST, AND SLOWLY.
He's alive. Unhurt. He's in Mumbai.
Does he know I'm alive?
Not yet.


SHE WROTE IT DOWN.
Q1. Where → Answered
Q2. Who → Answered
Q3. How long → Answered
Q4. Bhaiya → Answered
But one answer was "not yet."

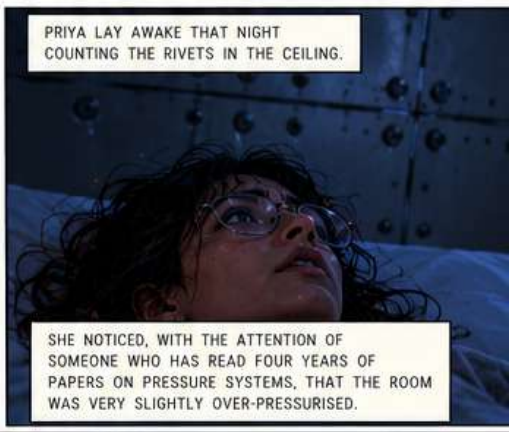

ON THE THIRD DAY SHE WALKED OUT. THE DOOR WAS UNLOCKED, WHICH SHOULD HAVE TOLD HER SOMETHING.
SHE MADE IT DOWN A CORRIDOR OF BARE ROCK, PAST GREY-UNIFORMED MEN WHO DID NOT STOP HER, TO AN EXTERIOR AIRLOCK WITH A WHEEL ON IT AND THE MOUNTAIN WIND HOWLING ON THE FAR SIDE.


SHE HAD HER HAND ON THE WHEEL WHEN A HEAVY MAN WITH A QUIET VOICE STEPPED OUT OF THE SHADOW.
Miss Mehta. Please don't.
HE HELD SOMETHING SMALL IN HIS RIGHT HAND, LIKE A TUNING FORK. HE DID NOT THREATEN HER WITH IT. HE SIMPLY TOUCHED A STUD.

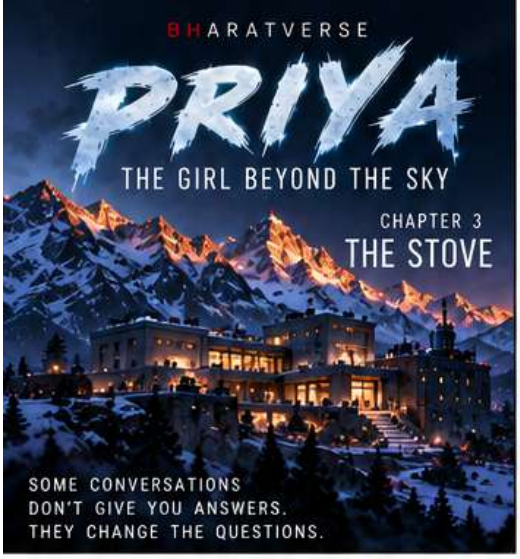

SOMETHING INSIDE HER, SOMETHING SHE HAD NOT KNOWN SHE HAD, WAS PULLED SIDEWAYS LIKE A THREAD YANKED FROM CLOTH.
HER KNEES WENT. THE EDGES OF THE WORLD TURNED WHITE. SHE WAS ON THE FLOOR AND COULD NO LONGER FEEL WHAT SHE HAD FELT A MOMENT BEFORE, THE FAINT SILVER LATTICE HUMMING AT THE EDGE OF EVERYTHING, AND ITS ABSENCE WAS WORSE THAN PAIN.


"THAT'S A KAMPAN UNIT," TARA SAID LATER, SITTING ON THE BED, VERY PALE.
It takes the force out of phase. It won't hurt you permanently. It was necessary.

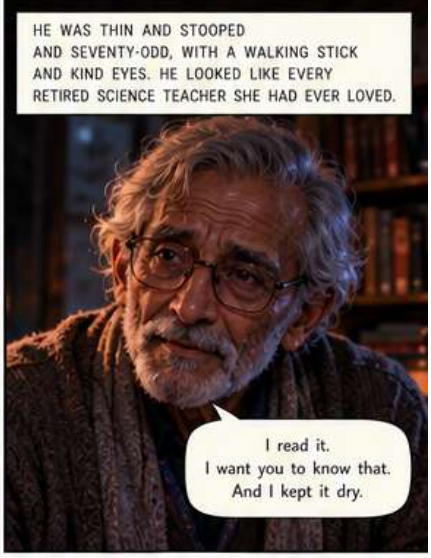

Necessary for whom?
TARA LOOKED AT HER HANDS. SHE DID NOT ANSWER.


PRIYA LAY AWAKE THAT NIGHT COUNTING THE RIVETS IN THE CEILING.
SHE NOTICED, WITH THE ATTENTION OF SOMEONE WHO HAS READ FOUR YEARS OF PAPERS ON PRESSURE SYSTEMS, THAT THE ROOM WAS VERY SLIGHTLY OVER-PRESSURISED.

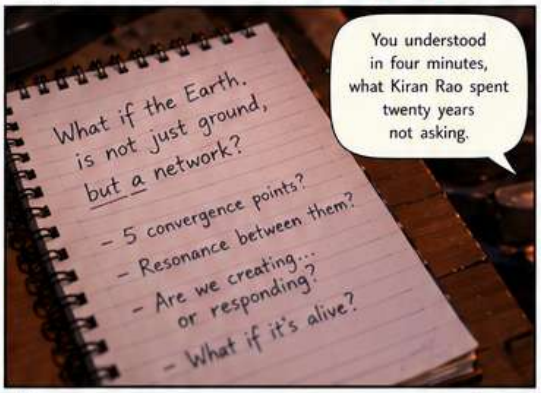

SOMEONE HAD BUILT THIS PLACE TO KEEP SOMETHING IN.
OR OUT.


BHARATVERSE
PRIYA
THE GIRL BEYOND THE SKY
CHAPTER 3
THE STOVE
SOME CONVERSATIONS
DON'T GIVE YOU ANSWERS.
THEY CHANGE THE QUESTIONS.


ON THE SEVENTH DAY
THEY TOOK HER TO MEET HIM.
Anand Kulkarni. The staff call me the Acharya. I wish they wouldn't. Please sit.

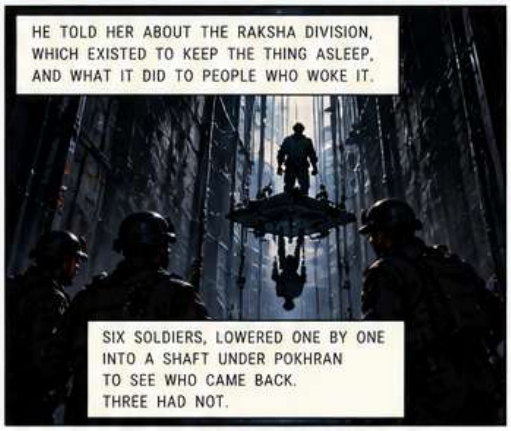

HE WAS THIN AND STOOPED AND SEVENTY-ODD, WITH A WALKING STICK AND KIND EYES. HE LOOKED LIKE EVERY RETIRED SCIENCE TEACHER SHE HAD EVER LOVED.
I read it. I want you to know that. And I kept it dry.


HE OPENED A DRAWER, TOOK OUT A CHEAP SPIRAL NOTEPAD, AND LAID IT ON THE DESK BETWEEN THEM.
"What if something is answering?"
HER OWN HANDWRITING ON THE TOP PAGE.


What if the Earth, is not just ground, but a network?
- 5 convergence points?
- Resonance between them?
- Are we creating... or responding?
- What if it's alive?
You understood in four minutes, what Kiran Rao spent twenty years not asking.

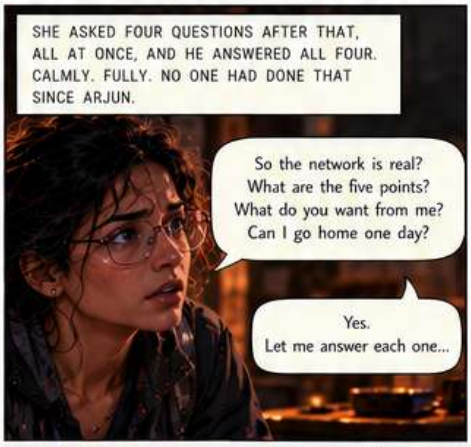

Can you hear it? That low tone. Beneath hearing.
...I can. Ever since the chamber.


"I HAVE HEARD IT SINCE 1974," HE SAID.
HE TOLD HER ABOUT A MORNING ON A DESERT RANGE, A RING OF WHITE-GOLD FIRE ON BARE SAND, AND A PAPER HE HAD SIGNED.


HE TOLD HER ABOUT THE RAKSHA DIVISION, WHICH EXISTED TO KEEP THE THING ASLEEP, AND WHAT IT DID TO PEOPLE WHO WOKE IT.
SIX SOLDIERS, LOWERED ONE BY ONE INTO A SHAFT UNDER POKHRAN TO SEE WHO CAME BACK. THREE HAD NOT.

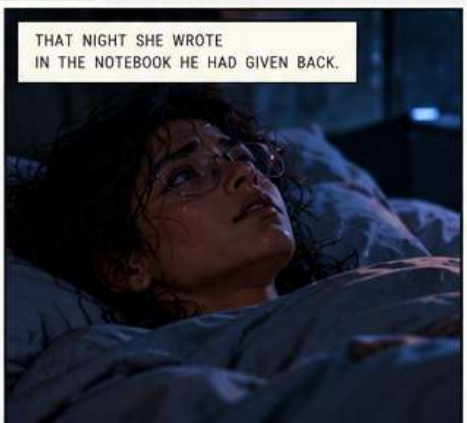

"I DIDN'T TAKE YOU, PRIYA. I REACHED YOU FIRST. THERE ARE PEOPLE IN DELHI WHO WOULD HAVE PUT YOU IN A ROOM UNDER THE DESERT AND FED YOU INTO A FURNACE UNTIL THEY UNDERSTOOD YOU."
RAKSHA DIVISION
CLASSIFIED

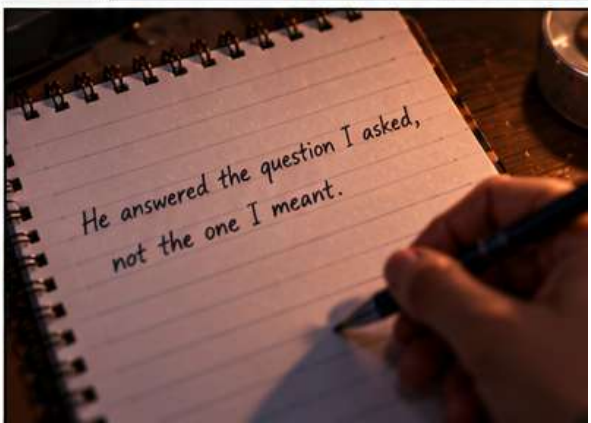

Why am I here?
Every civilisation that has lasted was held up by something it chose not to look at. I have simply decided to look.


SHE ASKED FOUR QUESTIONS AFTER THAT, ALL AT ONCE, AND HE ANSWERED ALL FOUR. CALMLY. FULLY. NO ONE HAD DONE THAT SINCE ARJUN.
So the network is real? What are the five points? What do you want from me? Can I go home one day?
Yes. Let me answer each one...


Did you cause Aheri?
Kiran Rao pushed the chamber to a hundred and forty per cent. Your brother's report warned her about wall 7-C. She signed over it.
Your brother was the only person in that building who did his job.


SHE WEPT THEN, A LITTLE, AND HATED THAT SHE DID.


THAT NIGHT SHE WROTE IN THE NOTEBOOK HE HAD GIVEN BACK.


He answered the question I asked, not the one I meant.

BHARATVERSE

PRIYA

THE GIRL BEYOND THE SKY

CHAPTER 4

THE FIFTH THREAD



FIVE THREADS.
FOUR VESSELS.
ONE GAP.
AND A GIRL WHO FELS EVERYTHING.

THE NAME ON HER DOOR WAS AKASH. EVERY MORNING SHE TOOK A PENCIL FROM THE DESK AND WROTE PRIYA UNDERNEATH, SMALL AND NEAT.



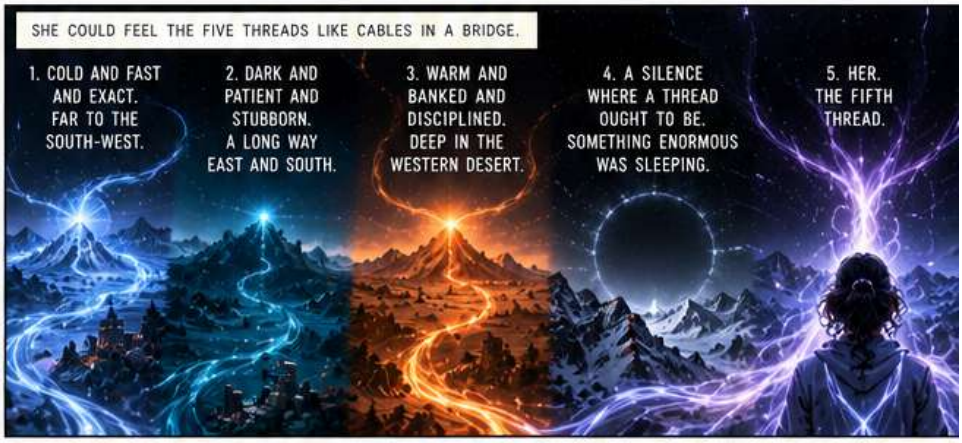
EVERY NIGHT SOMEONE ERASED IT. SHE DID NOT KNOW WHO. SHE WROTE IT AGAIN THE NEXT MORNING, AND THE ONE AFTER THAT.



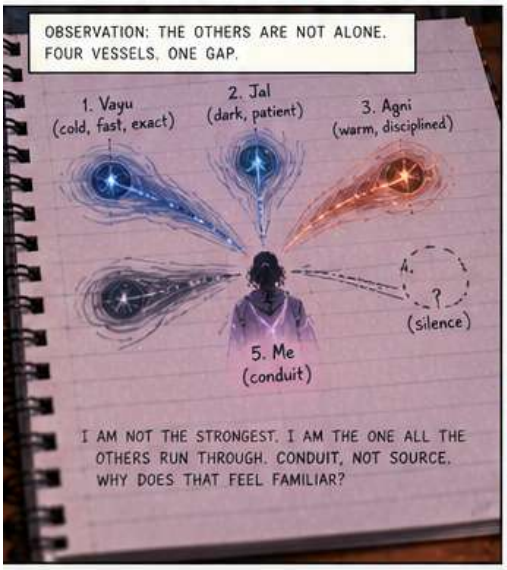
DR. MENON TAUGHT HER TO LISTEN. IT WAS THE RIGHT WORD, AND THE ONLY ONE. THAT FIT. THE LATTICE SHE HAD SEEN IN THE CHAMBER WAS STILL THERE AT THE EDGE OF EVERYTHING.



SHE COULD FEEL THE FIVE THREADS LIKE CABLES IN A BRIDGE.



OBSERVATION: THE OTHERS ARE NOT ALONE. FOUR VESSELS. ONE GAP.



I AM NOT THE STRONGEST. I AM THE ONE ALL THE OTHERS RUN THROUGH. CONDUIT, NOT SOURCE. WHY DOES THAT FEEL FAMILIAR?

ON THE FOURTEENTH DAY SHE CARRIED HEAT. DR. MENON LIT A SMALL STOVE ACROSS THE ROOM AND ASKED HER TO MOVE THE WARMTH INTO A COLD FLASK ON THE DESK.





SHE TRIED FOR AN HOUR AND FAILED.



THEN SHE STOPPED TRYING TO PUSH AND LET IT PASS THROUGH HER INSTEAD.



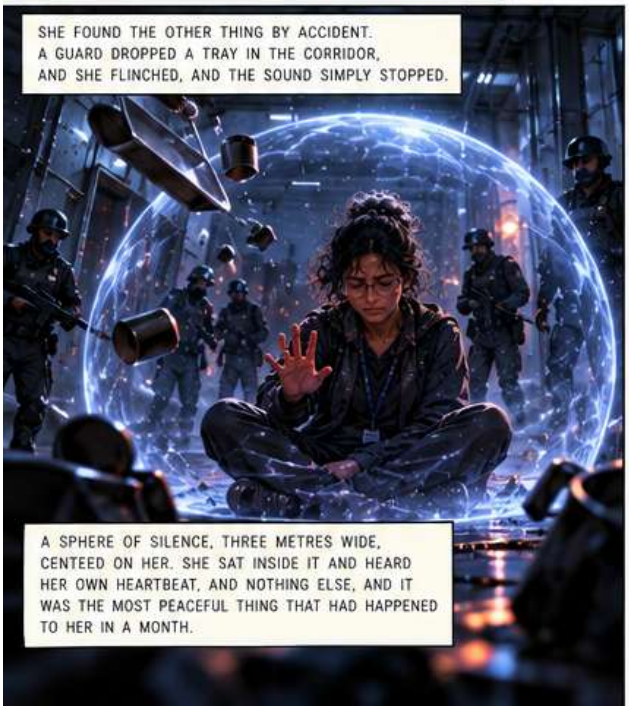
THE FLASK GREW WARM IN HER HANDS WHILE THE STOVE BURNED DOWN.

SHE THOUGHT OF THE QUESTIONS SHE HAD ASKED AS A CHILD.



SHE WAS NOT A CLOUD, BUT SHE UNDERSTOOD NOW WHAT HOLDING WAS.

SHE FOUND THE OTHER THING BY ACCIDENT. A GUARD DROPPED A TRAY IN THE CORRIDOR, AND SHE FLINCHED, AND THE SOUND SIMPLY STOPPED.



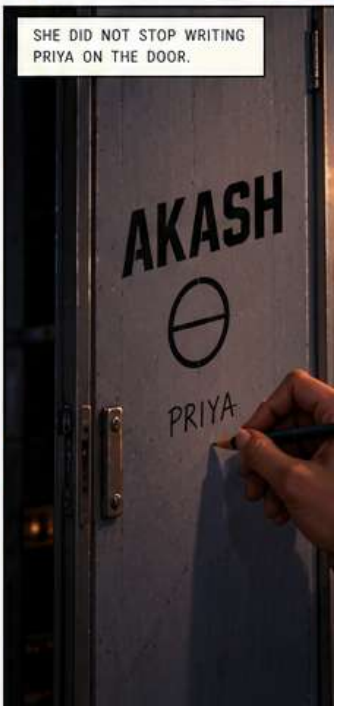
A SPHERE OF SILENCE, THREE METRES WIDE, CENTEED ON HER. SHE SAT INSIDE IT AND HEARD HER OWN HEARTBEAT, AND NOTHING ELSE, AND IT WAS THE MOST PEACEFUL THING THAT HAD HAPPENED TO HER IN A MONTH.

TARA MENON WAS GOOD AT THE WORK AND KIND ABOUT IT.



SHE SAID "WELL DONE" LIKE A WOMAN WHO MEANT IT. PRIYA HATED HOW EASILY SHE COULD LIKE HER.

SHE DID NOT STOP WRITING PRIYA ON THE DOOR.



BHARATVERSE

PRIYA

THE GIRL BEYOND THE SKY

CHAPTER 5

TWELVE SECONDS



SOME TRUTHS CAN'T BE HIDDEN.
THEY ONLY ARRIVE LATER.

HE SHOWED HER THE VIDEO ON A SUNDAY, WITH THE STOVE TICKING AND SNOW AGAINST THE GLASS.



TWELVE SECONDS.
THE AIR BENDING AROUND HIM.
A WOMAN FALLING.
AND THEN LANDING.



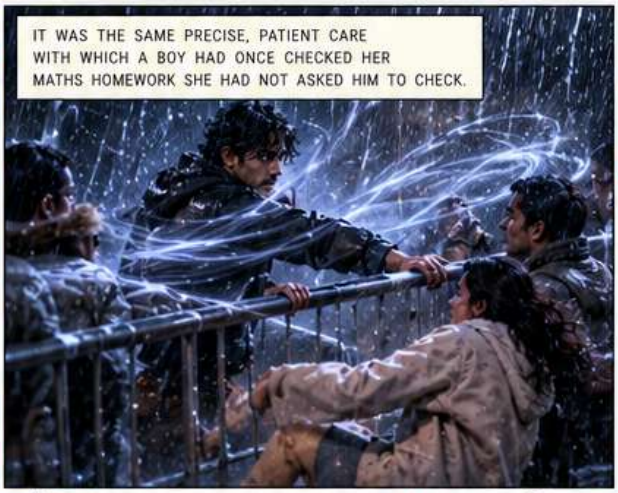
SHE WATCHED IT ONCE AND SAID NOTHING.

THE WIND-THREAD HAD FLARED IN HER HEAD THE MOMENT THE FIGURE MOVED, AND SHE KNEW ITS GRAIN.



SHE HAD KNOWN IT SINCE SHE WAS FIVE.

IT WAS THE SAME PRECISE, PATIENT CARE WITH WHICH A BOY HAD ONCE CHECKED HER MATHS HOMEWORK SHE HAD NOT ASKED HIM TO CHECK.



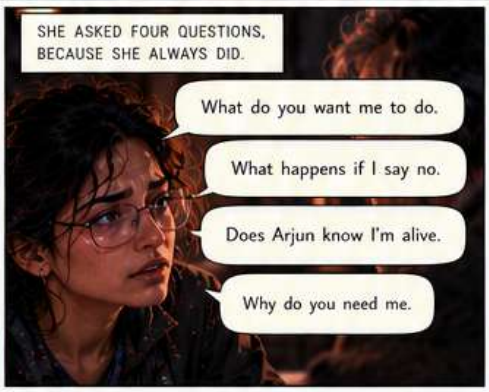


HE LOOKED AT HER FOR A LONG TIME.
HE KNEW SHE WAS LYING.
HE LET HER.

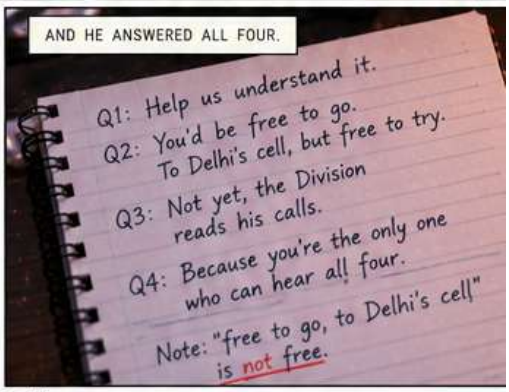
"The Division has a file on him," he said. "They've been watching since Nagpur. They will offer him a seat at a table. The table will have a collar on it."



SHE ASKED FOUR QUESTIONS, BECAUSE SHE ALWAYS DID.



AND HE ANSWERED ALL FOUR.



THAT NIGHT SHE WATCHED THE CLIP AGAIN, ALONE, ON A TABLET TARA HAD LEFT BY MISTAKE.



SHE STOPPED IT AT THE EXACT FRAME WHERE THE FIGURE TURNED HIS HEAD TOWARD THE CAMERA.



HIS FACE WAS BLURRED, WET, AND UNMISTAKABLE.
HE LOOKED TERRIFIED.

IT WAS THE FIRST TIME SHE CRIED IN FRONT OF A SCREEN SINCE SHE WAS TWELVE.



SHE FELT THE WIND-THREAD TUG AT HER LIKE A HAND AT A SLEEVE.



A VERY FAINT PRESSURE, VERY FAR AWAY, THE WAY A PERSON'S ATTENTION CAN FEEL LIKE A TOUCH.

SHE DID NOT TELL ANYONE.



SHE DID NOT KNOW YET HOW TO TELL THEM WITHOUT LOSING IT.

BHARATVERSE

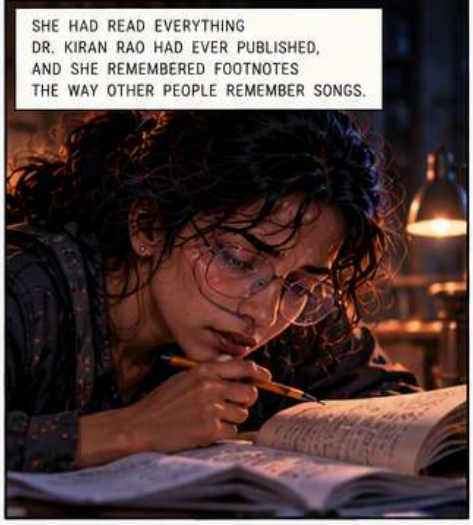
PRIYA

THE GIRL BEYOND THE SKY

CHAPTER 6

THE CIRCLE

SOME SYMBOLS
CONNECT MORE THAN PLACE.
THEY CONNECT PEOPLE.



SHE HAD READ EVERYTHING
DR. KIRAN RAO HAD EVER PUBLISHED,
AND SHE REMEMBERED FOOTNOTES
THE WAY OTHER PEOPLE REMEMBER SONGS.

IT TOOK HER ELEVEN WEEKS
TO PLACE THE SYMBOL.



ON THE DOOR HANDLES.



STENCILLED UNDER HER NAME.



ON EVERY FOLDER.



IN TARA MENON'S LANYARD.

SHE HAD SEEN IT SOMEWHERE ELSE.
NOT HERE. NOT RECENTLY.

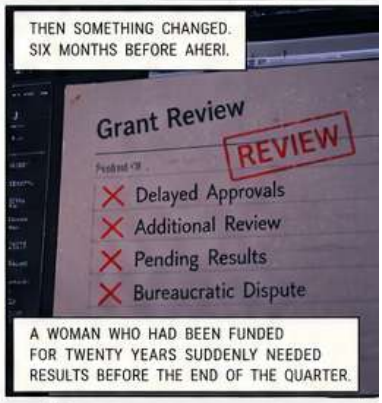


IN SMALL TYPE, IN THE LAST
PARAGRAPH OF A PAPER.

EVERY PAPER SINCE 2004.
THE SAME CIRCLE ON THE GRANT LETTERHEAD.
DR. RAO HAD ONCE PHOTOGRAPHED FOR A CONFERENCE SLIDE.

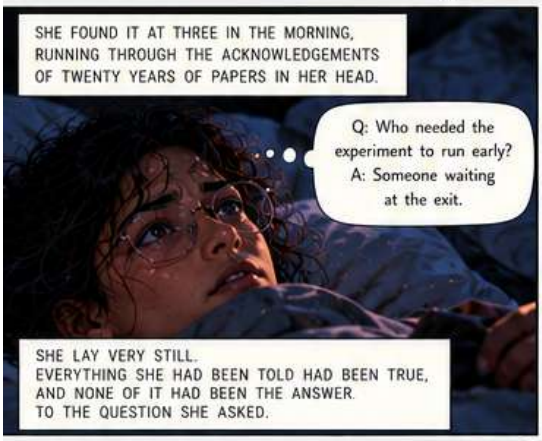


THEN SOMETHING CHANGED.
SIX MONTHS BEFORE AHERI.



A WOMAN WHO HAD BEEN FUNDED
FOR TWENTY YEARS SUDDENLY NEEDED
RESULTS BEFORE THE END OF THE QUARTER.

SHE FOUND IT AT THREE IN THE MORNING,
RUNNING THROUGH THE ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS
OF TWENTY YEARS OF PAPERS IN HER HEAD.



SHE LAY VERY STILL.
EVERYTHING SHE HAD BEEN TOLD HAD BEEN TRUE,
AND NONE OF IT HAD BEEN THE ANSWER
TO THE QUESTION SHE ASKED.

THE NEXT DAY, IN THE CABINET OUTSIDE TARA'S LAB,
SHE FOUND A TABLE.

Projected Conduction Load Across the Five Vessels

Vessel	Element	Expected Load (TW)	Stability Range	Keystone	Full Link Status	Survival (Est.)
Vayu	Wind	1.2	Stable	✓	–	62%
Jal	Water	1.5	Stable	✓	–	58%
Agni	Fire	1.3	Controlled	✓	–	49%
Prithvi	Earth	1.8	Unstable	–	Partial	21%
Akash	Conduit	2.4	Critical	–	Full Link	4%

AT THE BOTTOM OF THE LAST COLUMN,
UNDER KEYSTONE, FULL LINK,
A FIGURE SHE READ THREE TIMES.

Full Link Status	Survival (Est.)
–	62%
–	58%
–	49%
Partial	21%
Full Link	4%

SHE DID NOT HEAR TARA COME IN.
SHE ONLY KNEW IT WHEN THE ROOM CHANGED.





SHE PICKED UP HER TEA FROM THE DESK.
SHE DID NOT CLOSE THE FOLDER.
SHE WALKED OUT, AND LEFT THE DOOR OPEN.

AND IT WAS, PRIYA UNDERSTOOD,
AN ACT OF TREASON.

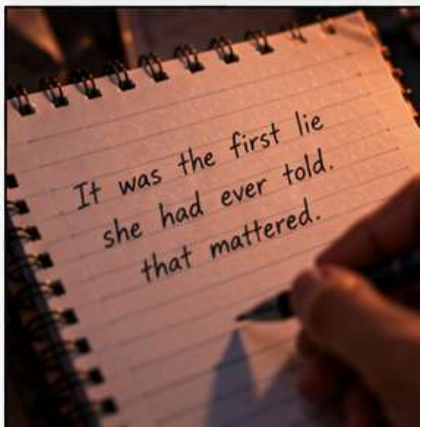
SHE TOLD NO ONE.



THAT EVENING DR. KULKARNI
ASKED HOW SHE WAS FEELING,
AND SHE SAID "BETTER,"
AND SMILED AT HIM WITH THE EXACT
CALM FACE HER BROTHER WORE
WHEN HE SAID HE WAS FINE.







BHARATVERSE

PRIYA

THE GIRL BEYOND THE SKY

CHAPTER 7

FIVE ROPES



SOME TRUTHS ARE PULLED.
SOME ARE ENDURED.
AND SOME ARE SILENCED.

VOSS DID IT WHILE KULKARNI WAS AWAY. THE ACHARYA HAD GONE DOWN THE MOUNTAIN FOR FOUR DAYS, TO A MEETING THAT TARA WOULD NOT DESCRIBE.



VOSS HAD BEEN PATIENT FOR ELEVEN YEARS, AND HE HAD COME TO THE END OF IT.

THEY PUT HER IN THE CHAMBER WITH THREE KAMPAN UNITS SET AT THE EDGES AND TURNED THE WRONG WAY, NOT TO PULL A FORCE OUT OF HER BUT TO OPEN HER UP.



THEY WANTED TO KNOW WHERE THE OTHER FOUR WERE. THEY WANTED HER TO REACH.

IT WAS LIKE BEING A BRIDGE. WHEN FIVE TRAINS GO OVER AT ONCE.

1. THE COLD, EXACT HAND TO THE SOUTH-WEST.



2. THE DARK, STUBBORN WATER.



3. THE BANKED FIRE. IN THE DESERT.



4. THE SILENCE.



5. ALL TOGETHER. FIVE ROPES PULLED TAUT THROUGH A SINGLE HAND.



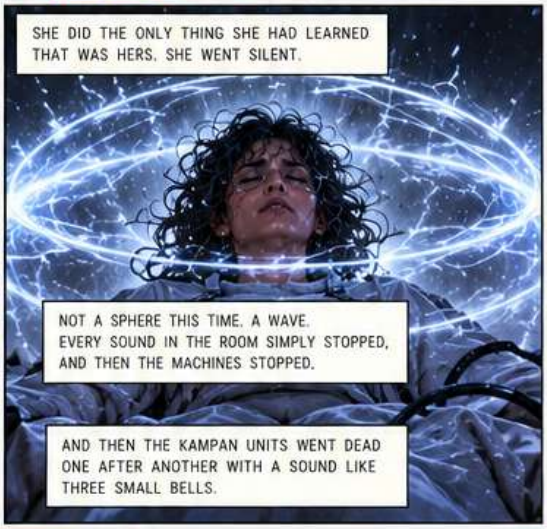
SHE HEARD TARA SHOUTING NUMBERS. SHE HEARD SOMETHING GIVE IN HER CHEST.



HER HEART STUTTERED, CAUGHT, STUTTERED AGAIN.

SHE THOUGHT: FOUR PER CENT. I AM NOT GOING TO BE A NUMBER IN A COLUMN.

SHE DID THE ONLY THING SHE HAD LEARNED THAT WAS HERS. SHE WENT SILENT.



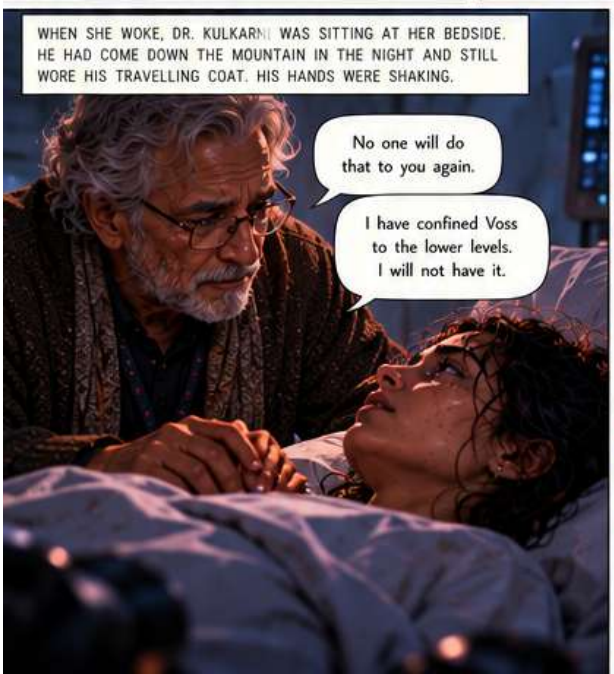
NOT A SPHERE THIS TIME. A WAVE. EVERY SOUND IN THE ROOM SIMPLY STOPPED, AND THEN THE MACHINES STOPPED.

AND THEN THE KAMPAN UNITS WENT DEAD ONE AFTER ANOTHER WITH A SOUND LIKE THREE SMALL BELLS.

VOSS WAS THROWN AGAINST THE FAR WALL. THE LIGHTS WENT OUT. THE THREADS FELL SLACK, AND SHE FELL WITH THEM.



WHEN SHE WOKE, DR. KULKARNI WAS SITTING AT HER BEDSIDE. HE HAD COME DOWN THE MOUNTAIN IN THE NIGHT AND STILL WORE HIS TRAVELLING COAT. HIS HANDS WERE SHAKING.



SHE BELIEVED HIM. THAT WAS THE MOST DANGEROUS PART. HE MEANT EVERY WORD.



HE DID NOT SAY I WOULD NEVER NEED TO ASK. HE DID NOT SAY OF COURSE.

HE SAID: "NO."

SHE WROTE THAT NIGHT.



BHARATVERSE

PRIYA

THE GIRL BEYOND THE SKY

CHAPTER 8

FOUR SECONDS

SOME CONNECTIONS
CANNOT BE STOPPED.
THEY ONLY FIND A WAY.

IT HAPPENED ON A NIGHT WITH NO MOON. PRIYA WAS LYING AWAKE IN THE WHITE ROOM WITH THE WINDOW OPEN A HAND'S WIDTH, BECAUSE SHE LIKED THE COLD.

THE LATTICE HUMMED AT THE EDGE OF HER MIND. FAR TO THE WEST, THE BANKED FIRE FLARED. AND AT THE SAME MOMENT, TO THE SOUTH-WEST, THE COLD EXACT THREAD OF HER BROTHER'S WIND CAME INTO THE SAME PLACE. TWO VESSELS IN ONE ROOM.

SHE DID NOT KNOW WHERE. SHE KNEW ONLY WHAT CAME THROUGH THE THREADS: HEAT, AND PRESSURE, AND A BUILDING FOLDING IN AND OUT LIKE A LUNG. AND ELEVEN LIVES IN A SEALED ROOM.

THEN A VOICE CARRIED ALONG THE FIRE-THREAD. A MAN'S VOICE, QUIET, ALMOST GENTLE.

Priya.

THE WIND-THREAD BROKE. SHE FELT IT GO LIKE A CABLE SNAPPING UNDER LOAD. EVERYTHING SHE HAD FELT OF HER BROTHER IN MONTHS CAME APART AT ONCE.

THE WHOLE BUILDING FLEXED. THE ELEVEN LIVES UNDER THE ROOF BEGAN TO SCREAM.

SHE REACHED THROUGH THE LATTICE AND DID NOT SEND HIM A FORCE. SHE SENT HIM A SILENCE.

ONE. TWO. THREE. FOUR.

ON FOUR, THE THREAD STEADIED. THROUGH IT SHE FELT HIM COME BACK UP OUT OF THE WATER BY HIS OWN COLLAR. SHE FELT THE ROOF TAKE ITS WEIGHT. SHE FELT A SECOND PRESENCE, THE FIRE, BENDING TOWARD THE SAME WORK.

IN THE FIRE, A HEAT THAT WAS NOT ANGER BUT SOMETHING CLOSER TO SHAME.

SHE DID NOT KNOW THE MAN. SHE DID NOT FORGIVE HIM. SHE FILED IT.

SHE HAD BEEN TOLD CONDUCTION WAS ONE-WAY. NO ONE HAD THOUGHT TO TELL HER ABOUT THE OTHER DIRECTION.

THE ALARMS CAME ON IN THE CORRIDOR A MINUTE LATER. TARA MENON APPEARED IN THE DOORWAY IN HER NIGHTCLOTHES, AND BEHIND HER, DR. KULKARNI.

What did you do?

I answered.

He's my brother.

You told me the Division would put a collar on him. You didn't tell me they would use my name to do it.

KULKARNI'S FACE DID SOMETHING SHE HAD NOT SEEN IT DO BEFORE. A HUNGER FIRST, QUICK AND BRIGHT. THEN, SLOWER AND COLDER. THE LOOK OF A MAN WHO HAS JUST UNDERSTOOD THAT THE MACHINE CAN ANSWER BACK.

HE DID NOT SPEAK. BEHIND HIM, TARA LOOKED AT THE FLOOR.

Goodnight, Dr. Kulkarni.

AKASH ⊖ PRIYA

WHEN THEY HAD GONE SHE STOOD AT THE DOOR WITH A PEN SHE HAD TAKEN FROM TARA'S DESK, AND UNDER THE STENCILLED AKASH SHE WROTE PRIYA IN INK. SHE DID NOT WAIT FOR DIT ITC BE ERASED.

FAR IN THE DARK, IN THE PLACE WHERE A THREAD SHOULD HAVE BEEN, SOMETHING ENORMOUS TURNED IN ITS SLEEP AND, VERY FAINTLY, ANSWERED.

A BUILDING DOES NOT COLLAPSE WITHOUT WARNING. IT ALWAYS TELLS YOU. SOMEWHERE ABOVE HER, IN A ROOM SHE HAD NOT YET SEEN, THE FIRST CRACK HAD BEGUN TO SHOW.

SHE WAS COMING BACK TO HIM. NOT YET. BUT SHE WAS COMING.